



FRESHMAN
ACADEMY

INTERNAL GUIDE · FOR DEPARTMENT LEADERS

Department Leadership Guidelines

How to lead a department at Freshman Academy: positioning, finances, team management, and the mindset required to deliver results.

VERSION

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APPROVED BY

Founder, Freshman Academy

OWNER

AP Department Leader



1 Positioning vs. Marketing

Every department leader must understand the difference between positioning and marketing. They are not the same thing, and confusing them leads to misdiagnosis of problems.

Positioning

This is about your genuine product strength. It lives inside product development and program management. Positioning means you have found your niche and you are genuinely the best at it. For Freshman Admissions, the positioning is strong: best systems, best people, best process. Positioning is reality.

Marketing

This is the game of perception. Marketing lives in the world of how people see you. You can have excellent positioning and still lose on the marketing side because you are not working with parents, not making bold claims, not getting featured in media, not showing up where your audience is. Both must be worked on separately and deliberately.

2 Competitive Advantage

Understand where your department stands relative to competitors and build a value proposition strong enough that the choice becomes obvious.

- Your value proposition must be **2 to 3 times better** than what competitors offer. Not slightly better. Undeniably better.
- Distribution disadvantages (fewer students in pipeline, smaller channels) can be overcome by a stronger offering. A much better product reaching fewer people still wins.
- Think about what you can add: free first sessions, bundled admissions support, a platform, exclusive content. The offering should be so compelling that the distribution gap stops mattering.
- Communicate the stronger offering through every available channel, including the Freshman Academics channel. Grow that channel with intention.
- Sales speed matters. From the moment someone shows interest to the moment they sign, time must be minimal. Bureaucratic delays cost you students.

The test

Could a prospective student or parent, after one interaction with your department, immediately understand why you are the better choice? If not, the positioning and marketing work is not done.



3 Finances and Incentive Systems

If the finances are right, almost everything else becomes easier. High margins allow reinvestment into marketing and people. Understand your numbers and structure your incentives accordingly.

Financial Structure

- Target a **40% reinvestment rate** back into the program. This is possible especially in the early stages.
- The remaining margin should be split between marketing spend and performance bonuses.
- Bonuses should be tied to clear enrollment targets: 12 students, 15 students, 20 students.
- Know your margins. If you do not know the cost per student and the revenue per student, you cannot make good decisions.

Feedback and Incentive System

- Separate the people who **deliver** the program from the people who **collect feedback**. Never let delivery staff collect their own feedback.
- Tie bonuses to satisfaction scores. If a teacher or program hits a certain score on the feedback form, they earn a bonus.
- This creates accountability at every level of the department, not just at the top.

4 Team Management

Pace is everything. Once you lose the rhythm of a team, restarting always costs more than maintaining it.

Weekly meetings	Non-negotiable. Every week, same structure: what was planned, what was delivered, what is next.
Check-ins	Do not wait for the weekly meeting to know what is happening. Regular informal check-ins keep problems from becoming surprises.
Deliverables and deadlines	Every team member must have clear deliverables with specific deadlines. Vague assignments produce vague results.
Marketing coordination	Work directly with the marketing team. Be creative. Do not rely on memes and filler content: bring real value from your department to the audience.
Goals and deadlines	Non-negotiable. Missing goals and deadlines consistently puts the whole department at risk. Hold the standard every week.



5 Leadership Qualities Required

Leading a department at Freshman means leading people who may be peers. The following qualities are not optional. They define whether the department moves or stalls.

1

Voice and Presence

A leader must be heard and felt in the room. Not just volume, but conviction. When you run a session, people should feel that someone is genuinely in charge. This is a skill. Practice it. Push yourself into a slight crisis mode: you need to deliver, and your team needs to feel that energy.

2

Planning and Intuition

Set a plan. Compare it to results. Do this consistently and you build intuition: the ability to make fast, accurate decisions without needing to go deep into every detail. Good intuition means you can sense when a deal, a contract, or a plan does not work at the level of principles, before you have even read the numbers. That is what you are building toward.

3

Proactiveness

Do not just continue what came before. Synthesize ideas from different fields, from what you watch, read, and experience day to day. Get inspired and bring that energy into how you develop and run your department. The leaders who grow fastest are the ones who steal good ideas from everywhere.

4

Motivating Peers

Some of the people you lead will be your peers or even older than you. Your authority comes from your consistency, your knowledge, and your results, not from your title. Lead with those three things and the team will follow.

The bottom line

You can be genuinely great at the product and still lose if your marketing, your team rhythm, your financial discipline, and your leadership presence are not there. All of these must be worked on in parallel. That is what running a department means.



6 Goals, Deadlines, and Accountability

Everything in this document comes down to one thing: you set goals, you set deadlines, and you meet them. This is the non-negotiable foundation of running a department at Freshman.

- Every goal must have a number and a specific date. No exceptions.
- Every week, your department's performance is visible to leadership. There is nowhere to hide, and that is by design.
- If you are going to miss a deadline, say so before it happens, not after.
- Missed goals must come with an explanation and a revised plan, not silence.
- The pace of weekly planning, delivery, and review is what separates departments that grow from departments that stall.

From leadership

If you do not meet goals and deadlines consistently, we are in trouble. This is not a threat. It is a fact of how organizations work. The standard is high because the vision is high.

APPROVED BY · FOUNDER

Valera Arakelyan
Freshman Academy

COO

Shakhzod Kadirov
Freshman Academy

OWNER

Niyozbek Komilov
AP Department Leader